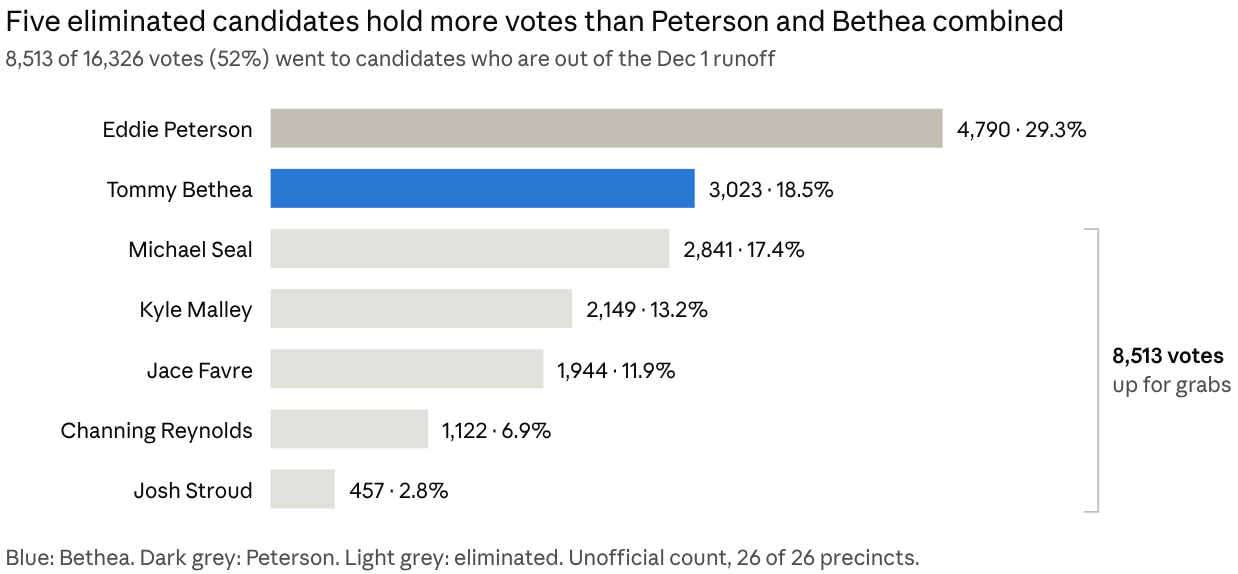
Bethea for Sheriff: Runoff Plan

Nov 6, 2026 · @Adam

Where the race stands

Tommy is in the Dec 1 runoff against Eddie Peterson, down 4,790 to 3,023, and the race will be decided by the 8,513 people who voted for someone else.



Hancock County Circuit Clerk unofficial results via WXXV and WLOX, Nov 3, 2026

Three things follow from the numbers:

1. **71% of the county voted against Peterson.** He is the frontrunner, not the favorite.
2. **Tommy barely made the runoff.** He beat Michael Seal for second by 182 votes. Seal's voters are the biggest single prize and they have no reason yet to pick either man.
3. **The runoff is Tuesday, Dec 1, the Tuesday after Thanksgiving.** Runoff turnout in Mississippi county races usually falls by a third or more. If everyone came back, Tommy would need about 60% of the eliminated candidates' voters. They will not all come back, so this is a turnout race: whoever gets his own people and the eliminated candidates' people to the polls wins.

The count is unofficial. Certified totals come from the Hancock County Circuit Clerk.

Who Eddie Peterson is

Peterson is a career cop with a south-county base and a message with no plan in it.

- **Career:** started at the Waveland Police Department, later Hancock County Sheriff's Office: patrolman, patrol supervisor, narcotics agent, criminal investigator. A third-party directory still lists him as a Waveland PD investigator.
- **Base:** Waveland and Bay St. Louis, the most populous end of the county. That is where his 4,790 most likely came from.
- **Message, in his own words:** "It's about giving the kids the same opportunity I had growing up in a safe community." "With growth comes crime. We have to put our resources in the right place." No numbers, no named problem, no specific promise.
- **Record:** nothing negative in the public record. No controversy, no lawsuit, no news story. Do not go looking to make one. A county this size punishes mud, and he is a clean cop.

His weak spots are structural: he is a city-PD man running for a county job, the north county has no reason to see him as theirs, and he has not told anyone what he would actually do.

The 8,513 votes up for grabs

Three issues carried about 6,000 of those votes: keeping deputies (pay), school safety, and drugs. Tommy talks about one thing today. Each man below, what he ran on, and how Tommy earns his voters:

Candidate	Votes	What he ran on	Who likely voted for him	How Tommy picks them up
Michael Seal (3rd)	2,841	Deputy retention through pay: cut waste in the budget and raise salaries so the job is a career, not a stepping stone. School safety. Ex-CEO, deputy since 2016.	Management-minded voters, deputies' families, Diamondhead-type retirees	Adopt his retention plan outright and credit him. Ask for his endorsement first: he finished 182 votes behind Tommy and his voters are the biggest prize.

Candidate	Votes	What he ran on	Who likely voted for him	How Tommy picks them up
Kyle Malley	2,149	Drugs and school safety. 21 years at HCSO, night-shift lieutenant for 16.	Department insiders, their families, north-county old-timers	Closest profile to Tommy (both long-tenure department men). The most natural endorsement and the easiest bloc. A joint video is worth more than any ad.
Jace Favre	1,944	"We need change." Transparency, more deputies on the road, retention. Tow-company owner, ex-HCSO K-9, ex-Bay St. Louis PD.	Anti-establishment, working-class, people fed up with the department	Hardest bloc for an insider. But "more deputies on the road" is Tommy's own line. Lean on that, and on Tommy being the lieutenant who never got the top job: not the old guard.
Channing Reynolds	1,122	Retention ("it goes back to how you treat them"), school safety, drugs, officer engagement. Business owner.	Small-business owners, deputies	Same retention story as Seal.
Josh Stroud	457	Under-patrolled areas, narcotics, human trafficking, jail problems. Ex-HCSO, ex-military contractor.	Rural north county, security-minded	"Under-patrolled areas" means Kiln, Necaise, Pearlington, Lakeshore. Name those places out loud.

None of the five had endorsed anyone as of Nov 6. The two calls that matter most are Malley and Seal, and they are phone calls, not posts.

The message pivot

Tommy's line is "more deputies on the street." Every one of those 8,513 voters is asking **how**, and the answer is sitting in the eliminated candidates' platforms.

Deputies leave for Harrison County and the city departments that pay more. You cannot put more cars on the road if you cannot keep the people in them. So the message becomes: *more deputies on the road, and here is how we keep them.* Five points, one page, each one specific:

1. **Keep the deputies we have.** Seal's plan: find the waste in the budget and move it to pay. Say a number once the campaign has the budget in hand.
2. **A deputy in every school.** School resource deputies, named by school.
3. **A drug unit that works the whole county**, north county included.
4. **Patrol zones for the north county.** Kiln, Necaise, Pearlington, Lakeshore, Diamondhead get named coverage, not leftover coverage.
5. **An open door.** A monthly town hall that rotates through the county, starting in Diamondhead.

Two things about delivery:

- **Specific beats warm.** Peterson's message is all warmth and no plan. Every Bethea piece should carry at least one number, one place name, or one named promise.
- **"They know me" is false in Diamondhead.** At the Sept 16 forum a resident said, "This is the first time in my life that I really don't know any of the candidates." Another: "someone that will communicate with us." That is Diamondhead talking: a big, high-turnout, mostly retired, mostly newer-resident bloc. Tommy's 19 years mean nothing to people who moved in five years ago. He has to go introduce himself there, in person, repeatedly, before Nov 25.

Promotions, ranked by votes per dollar

The two biggest moves cost nothing. Spend money only after the endorsements and the absentee list are in motion.

#	Move	Cost	Why it is ranked here
1	**Endorsements from Malley and Seal**, then one short video of the three of them together: "Tommy has our plan and our vote."	$0	4,990 votes between them. The single biggest move available. Phone calls, not posts.
2	**65+ absentee push** before Thanksgiving (next section)	$0 to ~$400 for a flyer	Turns the holiday from a problem into an edge.
3	**One-page plan and a real website** with the five points, his 19-year story, and absentee instructions	~$20 for the domain; the site is free to build and host	Today his only web presence is a donation page. Peterson has nothing either. Wins the "who is this guy" search.
4	**Five 30- to 60-second vertical videos**, one issue each, shot on a phone at a real place: a Kiln gas station, a school drop-off line, a Diamondhead street. Captioned, because people watch Facebook muted.	$0 to shoot; $50 to $100 each to boost	Facebook groups are the local newspaper in Hancock County. Post one a day the week of Nov 16, re-run them the week of Nov 30.
5	**Yard signs in the north county and Diamondhead**, not Waveland	$300 to $500 per 100	Fight where Peterson's base is not.
6	**One targeted mailer** to the precincts where Seal, Malley and Reynolds ran strongest	About $0.60 to $0.70 a piece	Needs the precinct results first.
7	**Earned media:** ask the Sea Coast Echo for a candidate Q&A and WQRZ 103.5 (Bay St. Louis community radio) for an interview	$0	Free press beats paid. WQRZ is noncommercial, so ask for an interview, not an ad.

Skip: TV, anything negative, anything that looks slick. A county sheriff race is won on "I know him and he showed up."

Calendar to Dec 1

1. **Nov 7 to 10:** Malley and Seal calls. Pull the precinct results and Peterson's finance report from the Circuit Clerk. Lock the five points. Register the domain.
2. **Nov 11 to 15:** Website live. One-pager printed. Shoot the five videos. Absentee flyer to Diamondhead and every 65+ door the campaign can reach.
3. **Nov 16 to 20:** Endorsement video out. One issue video a day. Tommy in Diamondhead and the north county every evening. Mailer drops.
4. **Nov 21 to 25:** Absentee voting push peaks. Last Diamondhead town hall before the holiday. Signs up.
5. **Nov 26 to 29:** Thanksgiving. Nothing new; the videos re-run.
6. **Nov 30:** Reminder blast: polls, hours, bring a photo ID.
7. **Dec 1:** Election day. Rides for anyone who needs one.

The Thanksgiving problem and the 65+ play

Dec 1 is the Tuesday after Thanksgiving, and the people most likely to be out of town that week are the retirees who vote at the highest rates. Mississippi lets anyone 65 or older vote absentee with no other excuse, in person at the Circuit Clerk's office in Bay St. Louis or by mail.

So the play is simple: **get the 65+ vote cast before anyone leaves for the holiday.** One flyer and one Facebook post with four things on it:

- The Circuit Clerk's office address and hours, and that the office is open the Saturday morning before the election.
- "If you are 65 or older you can vote now. Bring your photo ID."
- How to request a mail ballot for anyone who cannot get to Bay St. Louis.
- Tommy's name and the five points on the back.

Diamondhead first, then every 65+ voter on the roll who voted Nov 3. Voter registration closed for this runoff on Nov 1, so there is nobody new to register; every vote has to come from people already on the roll.

Confirm the exact absentee start date and Saturday hours with the Circuit Clerk before anything prints.

What we still need, and the ground rules

Everything above gets sharper with four things that only the campaign or the Circuit Clerk can supply:

- [ ] **Precinct-by-precinct results** from the Hancock County Circuit Clerk. Shows exactly which boxes Seal and Malley won and where Peterson was weak. Drives the sign map and the mailer.
- [ ] **The county voter roll with vote history** (the Circuit Clerk sells it). That is the door-knock and absentee list: 65+, voted Nov 3, outside Waveland.
- [ ] **Peterson's campaign finance report**, filed with the Circuit Clerk and public. Shows who is funding him and how much he has.
- [ ] **The campaign's own numbers:** cash on hand, volunteers, and who is running it day to day.

Ground rules:

- Everything public goes out under Tommy's campaign, from his accounts and his people.
- Any money spent on his behalf has to run through his campaign treasurer and show up on his reports. No freelance spending.
- Nothing negative about Peterson. Nothing in his public record supports it, and it would cost more votes than it gains.
- Two open questions this report cannot answer from the outside: has either Malley or Seal already been approached, and does the campaign have a line to the Diamondhead community groups?

Sources

- WLOX: Meet the candidates running for Hancock County Sheriff (Sept 16, 2026), every candidate quote and career line above
- WLOX: Unofficial results send Peterson, Bethea to runoff (Nov 4, 2026), runoff date
- WXXV: Unofficial results, Hancock County sheriff's race heading to a runoff and WXXV: Nov 3 general election results, vote counts for all seven
- WLOX: Hancock County community gathers to learn about sheriff candidates (Sept 17, 2026), Diamondhead forum voter quotes
- Sea Coast Echo: Hancock Co. sheriff's race officially under way

- WLOX: Johnny Alison named new Hancock County Sheriff (Jan 22, 2026), why the seat is open
- Givebutter: Tommy Bethea for Sheriff 2026, his only web presence as of Nov 6
- ZoomInfo: Waveland Police Department directory, Peterson listed as investigator

All vote totals are unofficial as of the night of Nov 3. Costs are typical ranges, not quotes.